



THE CIVILITY ESSAYS

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CLOSING THOUGHTS



Introduction

Why Civility?

There was a time—not so long ago—when disagreement didn’t automatically mean division. It was a simpler time when neighbors sat out on the front stoop. They borrowed sugar and children played together in the streets. It was a time when kindness wasn’t considered old-fashioned. Somewhere along the way, as our lives gradually became faster, louder, more digital—more transactional—something subtle but significant began to erode: our **civility**.

I began writing a collection of essays on civility in 2019, not as a grand statement or philosophical project, but as a gentle attempt to restore what felt was becoming lost. Each was originally published as a short blog post—a simple reflection, grounded in everyday life, about how we can consciously decide to be kinder, more gracious, and more aware.

I didn’t anticipate the wonderful response they would generate. People shared with me how they enjoyed reading them, and how they were a cause for gentle reflection. They shared how a single thought or paragraph reminded them to call a parent, forgive a friend, or simply say thank you.

This told me that civility matters more than we realize.

This book is a collection of those essays—revised and expanded a bit to include some questions for personal reflection. Each one is an invitation. Not to be perfect. Not to pretend everything is okay. But to choose, in every moment, the person you want to be in the world.

Civility isn’t weakness. It is strength under control. It isn’t about people-pleasing. It’s about being real, authentic and grounded. It’s not about pretending to agree.

It’s about how we carry ourselves when we don’t.

I hope these essays inspire you to see civility not as a dated, antiquated ideal, but as a radical, necessary practice for today. I hope they help you build better relationships, stronger communities, and a deeper sense of peace within yourself.

So let’s begin—not with blame or bitterness—but with a deep breath, a brief pause, and the smallest act of compassion and grace.

Thank you for reading.

Jack





Civility

Civility is defined as courtesy, politeness; a polite act or expression. A few observations about civility:

1

The world works better with more civility.

2

Civility is something each of us can choose.

3

We can choose civility at any moment each day.

Civility Part 1: Getting Over Yourself

Originally posted 1/20/2019

"Life's most persistent and urgent question is, 'What are you doing for others?'"
— Martin Luther King Jr.

The foundation of civility is the ability to shift your focus from your own interests, wants, needs and concerns such that you can hear, understand and tend to the needs and interests of others.

Excessive self-focus is so limiting. You are only one person in a vast community of others. When you learn to tend to the needs of others, goodness expands.

The key to focusing more on the needs of others is to live with the realization that **you and your life are fine just as they are**. When you are aware of your abundance you have the freedom to notice the needs of those around you.

You can practice shifting your focus whenever you choose. What needs do you truly have in this very moment? Asking yourself that question may lead to the realization that, despite a tendency to worry about the unknown, in this moment almost every need is being met.

Now, consider someone who is nearby.

Take a moment to inquire about their welfare. Listen and consider what, if any, contribution you might make to them.

You can make a difference in the world by noticing and caring for someone today.



Civility Part 2: Being vs. Doing

Originally posted 11/16/2019

"We are not human doings. We are human beings."

— Deepak Chopra

My previous post focused on getting over yourself and putting the interests of others ahead of your own. Now, we shift to making who you are **being** more important than what you are **doing**.

Don't get me wrong, **doing** is important. Competence is fundamental to success. Hopefully, you have invested considerable time, resources and effort to master knowledge and skills that allow you be very useful to the world around you. You are sought after for your expertise and experience. You are able to give guidance to your business and to produce outstanding results. But who you are **being** may be even more important.

You know who you are **being** by how the people around you see you. You can be seen as demanding, harsh, kind, controlling, considerate, difficult, caring, mean-spirited, respectful, trustworthy and reliable or any number of other adjectives. Who you are being has to do with how you carry yourself, your values and how you interact with the people in your world.

Growing in who you are **being** is often more difficult than gaining competence because there are not as many opportunities for training. Growth in **being** used to be the domain of religious institutions, schools and the family. Now, you must seek mentors who demonstrate maturity, wisdom and well-cultivated **being**.

So, who are you **being**?

Tomorrow be a little more intentional to be a source of encouragement, inspiration and support.

In so doing, you will make the world a more civil place.

Civility Part 3: Learn to Play a Friendly Game of Tennis

Originally posted 11/20/2019

“Most people do not listen with the intent to understand; they listen with the intent to reply.”

— Stephen R. Covey

In previous posts, we focused on getting over yourself and making who you are **being** at least as important as what you are **doing**. Now, we add the critical skill of listening well. When you talk, you share your wisdom, judgments, knowledge, prejudices, wants and needs. Talking is critical for shaping the world as you want and need it to be. Until you know yourself well and know how to express yourself clearly, you won't have much power to shape your life and circumstances.

But when you listen...you **learn**! Learning is the path of expansion, of growth. Taking in new information allows you to add to and alter what you know. It makes you smarter and wiser. Listening trumps talking 90% of the time because it makes you better.

Notice that talking and listening are mutually exclusive. You can't talk and listen at the same time. Even when you aren't talking you may not be listening. How often when others are talking are you impatiently waiting to talk and so aren't really listening at all?

To be good at listening, you must learn to settle yourself, to be quiet, receptive and patient. I often describe this skill as learning to play a friendly game of tennis. You lob the ball over the net and then wait. You have no idea where or when the ball will come back your way but you are paying attention. Now, here it comes. You move to the right location and, hopefully, lob it back across the net.

When you are skilled at playing a friendly game of tennis, you aren't aggressive. You aren't trying to win. You are accommodating and easeful.

Practice this week. Notice when you aren't listening and let go of your opinion. Be fully present to what the other person is saying. See if you can rephrase what they said without changing it. Next, listen for the reason underlying their communication to you. Why did they say it? What do they want from you? Only when you have a pretty good sense, open your mouth and while saying as little as possible, lob the ball back to them.

Civility Part 4: It's a Wonderful Day in the Neighborhood

Originally posted 12/4/2019

"There is no person in the whole world like you, and I like you just the way you are."

— Fred Rogers

If you haven't yet done so, you must go to see the Mr. Rogers movie "A Beautiful Day in the Neighborhood." I was a bit skeptical. My recollection of Mr. Rogers was that he was too simple, sweet and innocent to be taken seriously.

How could anyone turn his story into a movie that would be interesting?

Nothing could have been further from the truth. While it is true that Fred Rogers was simple, sweet and innocent, he was also powerful, transforming and riveting. His principles were few in number and easy to understand.

- Everyone is unique and perfect just as they are.
- Be fully present with everyone you meet.
- We all need to learn to experience all of our emotions in constructive ways.

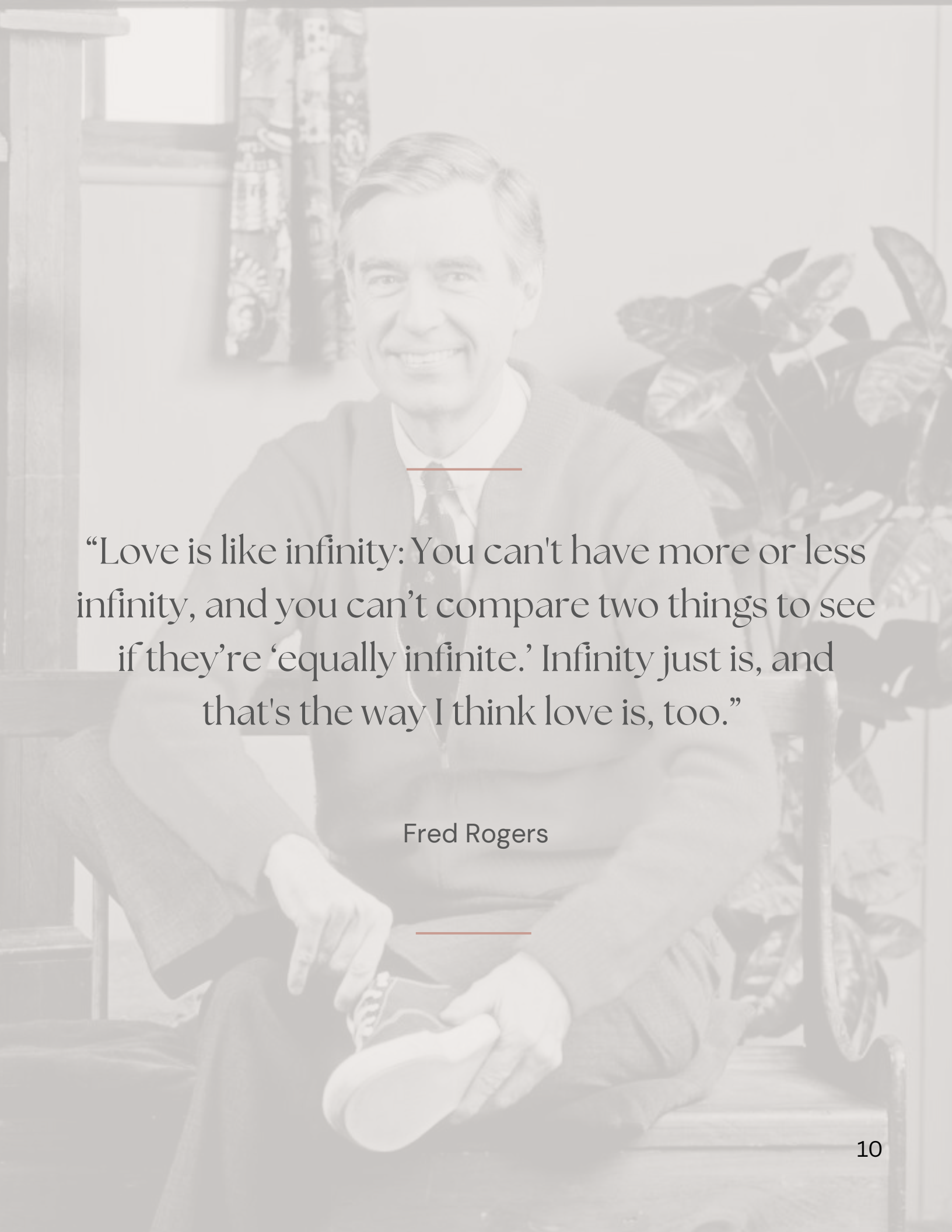
There may be more, but these three were obvious.

Imagine how different the world would be if everyone mastered these three simple principles. Judgment, hatred and violence would disappear. Mr. Rogers invited people to notice and voice their anger and then suggested banging the low keys on the piano to get rid of it. He knew that we all get frustrated and angry from time to time, but that holding it in or taking it out on others isn't the best way to deal with it.

Love and respect would grow as people really listened to, understood and accepted each other. Mr. Rogers had that effect on the people in his life. One line was especially poignant, "Do you know what is most important from me to do right now?" he asked.

"Be here with you." was the answer. Wow!

Despite all of the busyness of life, he took the time to truly get to know everyone he met. Mr. Rogers will touch your heart and inspire you to be an even better neighbor.



“Love is like infinity: You can't have more or less infinity, and you can't compare two things to see if they're 'equally infinite.' Infinity just is, and that's the way I think love is, too.”

Fred Rogers

Civility Part 5: Civility on Steroids (Christmas)

Originally posted 12/19/2019

“Peace on earth will come to stay, when we live Christmas every day.”

— Helen Steiner Rice

We’re in the thick of it now. Everyone is busy getting ready for Christmas.

Holiday parties to plan and attend. Gifts to buy. Houses to decorate. Dinners to plan. So much to do.

Such a rush.

Take a few moments to remember the Christmas story. A miraculous birth of a boy delivered in a stable. A young man raised as a carpenter who became a riveting voice among his people. His message was one of deliverance. He healed the sick. He gave sight to the blind. He forgave the sins of those who believed. He declared himself to be the way, the truth and the life. He gave himself up to be crucified to redeem the world.

Regardless of what you believe about Jesus, he demonstrated in his life and death who each of us can be. He lived with compassion, wisdom, courage, clarity and purpose.

He was at peace because he understood what we so easily forget. He never lost sight of the big picture and the majesty of who God intended us to be.

Merry Christmas to you and your family.

Thank you for sharing these few minutes with me.

Questions for Reflection (Essays 1 -5)

Civility Part 1: Getting Over Yourself

Reflection Question: In what situations do I tend to focus most on myself, and how might I shift my attention toward the needs of others in those moments?

Civility Part 2: Being vs. Doing

Reflection Question: How would the people closest to me describe who I am being—especially under stress or pressure?

Civility Part 3: Learning to Play a Friendly Game of Tennis

Reflection Question: In my recent conversations, have I truly listened—or have I been waiting to speak?

Questions for Reflection (Essays 1 -5)

Civility Part 4: It's a Wonderful Day in the Neighborhood

Reflection Question: What simple principle from Mr. Rogers' life could I embody more fully in how I treat others?

Civility Part 5: Civility on Steroids (Christmas)

Reflection Question: Amid the busyness of the season, how can I return to the deeper meaning of celebration—and extend grace to those around me?

Civility Part 6: Allies or Enemies?

Originally posted 1/2/2020

“You can’t shake hands with a clenched fist.”

— Indira Gandhi

In previous posts, we focused on getting over yourself, making who you are **being** at least as important as what you are **doing**, and the critical skill of listening well.

Now, we add managing your impact on each person you meet.

Some people lack awareness of when they are being offensive or off-putting. They don’t notice people backing off or shutting down because they are standing too close, saying inappropriate things, or dominating interactions.

Others may notice, but they don’t care. They are too focused on their agenda or so egotistical that they think it doesn’t matter how many people they offend. But they would be well served to realize the overwhelming value of having many allies and as few enemies as possible.

Allies want to see you succeed. They extend you the benefit of the doubt when your judgment is questionable. They gladly help you when you need support and come to your aid if you are in trouble. You can’t have too many allies.

On the other hand, enemies are dangerous. They root for you to fail. They will join forces to erode support you have from others. They will undermine you whenever they get the chance. Even one enemy can bring you down.

The key to gaining allies and avoiding enemies is to treat everyone with respect and dignity regardless of who they are.

Practice with the people who bag your groceries or deliver your mail. Be friendly. Show interest in their lives.

Notice what lights them up and what shuts them down—and do more of the former and less of the latter.

Civility Part 7: Being a Plow Horse or Reservoir

Originally posted 1/16/2020

“You can’t pour from an empty cup. Take care of yourself first.”

— Anonymous

Taking care of the people who matter to you is important. They depend on you to keep your word, to have their best interest in mind, to provide, and to be reliable. The success of family, friendships, business, governments, and societies is built on the commitment of good men and women to take good care of others. But there are two ways you can exercise that responsibility.

The first, and most common, is to be like a **plow horse**. A plow horse wakes up every morning to be hitched to a plow that it will pull through the field until the end of the day.

Day after day is the same; difficult, strenuous, exhausting work. The reward for being a good plow horse is a bag of oats at the end of the day. When you live like a plow horse, you take on caring for others as a burden that requires great personal sacrifice.

You are willing to do what is necessary in order to ensure your children have the opportunity to get a good education or live in the right neighborhood. You will secure the financial wellbeing of your family regardless of what it costs you.



(continued)

If this is you, you will likely feel anxious, pressured, frustrated, and, at times exhausted. You are caring for others at great expense to yourself. You are wearing yourself out trying to do the right thing.

The second way is to be a **reservoir**. Reservoirs are perpetually fed by springs and streams such that they overflow. All downstream that use the water from the reservoir do so without diminishing or draining it at all. The reservoir shares its abundance in great measure.

Imagine caring for others in this manner. You learn how to feed your aliveness, gifts, skills, and productivity in a way that you fill yourself full and overflowing. The people around you benefit greatly from all that you produce, and without draining you at all.

There is still time at the beginning of this New Year to commit to habits that feed and sustain you.

Consider the importance of regular times to contemplate that which is important to you and plan for what you want to create.

Consider the importance of adequate rest, fun, and friendship.

Consider the value in replacing habits that undermine you with ones that feed your vitality.



Civility Part 8: Loner or Lover?

Originally posted 1/30/2020

“Connection is why we’re here; it is what gives purpose and meaning to our lives.”

— Brené Brown

This is how Warren Buffet defined success:

“When you’re nearing your end of life, your only measure of success should be the number of people you want to have love you actually do love you. I know people who have a lot of money, and they get testimonial dinners and they get hospital wings named after them. But the truth is that nobody in the world loves them. If you get to my age in life and nobody thinks well of you, I don’t care how big your bank account is, your life is a disaster.”

Everyone needs to be part of a loving community, and the more the merrier. We weren’t meant to live in isolation. At the end of the day, everyone wants to come home to the community of family or friends who know who you really are, accept you for being yourself and who love you.

But some people are better at building community than others. I have 7 grandchildren who live close enough to me to visit. A number of years ago I struggled with how I wanted to shape my involvement in their lives. I came up with an idea that turned out to be brilliant, even though I didn’t know it at the time. I created Movie Night.

Movie Night has evolved into an amazingly rich community for me, my wife, our children and grandchildren who live close enough to attend.

And in the process, I discovered some powerful tips for building a rich and wonderful community. Over the next few posts I would like to share some of the lessons I learned in the hope that you can use them to enrich community in your life.

Your community might be your marriage, your family, your friends at school, or your neighbors. It doesn’t matter. Pick a group that is meaningful to you and use these tips to make it better for you and for those you care about.

Let’s start a community challenge. I will share my tips with you. Write back and share one tip you have used to make your community richer.

Civility Part 9: Community Building Tip 1: Intentionality

Originally posted 2/12/2020

"We were born to unite with our fellow human beings, and to join in community with the human race."

— Cicero

Community doesn't often naturally occur. It requires someone who has a vision. I could have been a grandfather in a variety of ways. I could have attended the kids' sporting events. I could have bought cool gifts for their birthdays. I could have taken them on trips. I could have ignored them altogether.

I wanted to build something they would experience as magical. Disney captures magic. You can feel it when you enter the park. Children like magic. I am not talking about magic tricks or black magic. I am talking about experiencing life as if for the first time, being excited, unguarded, and alive. Movie Night had to be about capturing the magic of childhood so that everyone would feel that feeling every time they got together. The magic would make Movie Night feel special.

I invested in a 3D big-screen television, surround sound, reclining furniture, and blankets. I bought movies that would appeal to kids of all ages and let them pick what they wanted to watch. They couldn't wait for the movie to start and hated it when their parents took them home before it was over.

Movie Night has evolved over the years. The grandchildren now range from the 3rd grade to a senior in high school. It has become progressively more difficult to find movies that interest them and are appropriate for everyone. But by adding a hot tub and pool table, everyone can do something that is magical.

Consider your community. What would make being together feel special?

What would make it stand out and make it an occurrence that people wouldn't want to miss out on?

What is your vision for the magic you want to create in your community?

Civility Part 9: Community Building Tip 2: Ritual

Originally posted 2/26/2020

Rituals are important because they become automatic cues for your community. They can promote warmth, caring, fun and mutual support. When you are building your community carefully select rituals that support your vision.

They don't have to be complicated. You may have a ritual of kissing your spouse and children when you come home. You may not even think of this as a ritual but it comes to signify the bond you share. You will notice the strength of such a ritual when someone violates it. If you don't give that expected kiss you are quite likely to be asked what is wrong.

Movie Night is always at 5:30 on Sunday night. The day has changed from time to time, but not often. It always starts with everyone sitting at a very long table (actually, two tables end to end). We hold hands and say grace. Then we eat and talk. It is often quite loud, but that is a sign that everyone feels comfortable participating in the conversation.

When dinner is over, everyone helps to clean up and then scatters to do whatever they choose. We come together later for dessert.

The Movie Night rituals allow everyone to know what to expect. They also help everyone shift into the spirit of the event.



Civility Part 9: Community Building Tip 3: Creativity

Originally posted 3/11/2020

Communities require change in order to thrive. If things are too predictable, people get bored and less committed. How can I get 13 children and grandchildren to want to get together every Sunday night when competing with sporting events, church meetings, boyfriends, girlfriends, and homework?

That was a tough problem to solve.

Then the lightbulb went off! Everyone likes to eat. I will make meals that are creative, different, and delicious. And we did! Movie nights often get named for whatever is being served. We have had Fried Chicken Movie Night, Lasagna Movie Night, Mexican Movie Night, Smoked Beef Tenderloin Movie Night...the list goes on and on.

But the change isn't enough. Linda (my amazing wife) and I strive to make the food as special as possible. Lasagna movie night isn't frozen lasagna or even packaged noodles. It is pasta made from scratch, ragout that takes half a day to cook and homemade béchamel. When we made Lamb Rogan Rosh, we had some ingredients imported from India.

The test of our creativity comes at the end of the meal when I ask the kids how much they would pay for it. At Chicken Enchilada Movie Night, our youngest grandson asked how much a restaurant would charge. Someone said \$15. He shouted, "I would pay \$30!"

It takes a lot of work to pull this off. Sometimes we cook all day or even start the day before. But when I see clean plates and family raving about the food, I have the satisfaction that I have fed my community in multiple ways.

What are you willing to do to infuse creativity into your community?

It doesn't have to be grand. The effort will be thinking it through, changing it up and keeping it going. Send me your ideas or whatever comes to mind.



Every moment is an
opportunity to choose
civility.

Civility Part 9: Community Building Tip 4: Fun

Originally posted 5/8/2020

Community must always be about having fun. Fun is an easy concept for children. They have the amazing ability to turn almost anything and everything into fun. They have a natural sense of wonder, amazing creativity and endless energy that allows them to turn a rug into a flying carpet, a hike into a wilderness adventure and a ride in the car into a sibling war!

We seem to lose our capacity for fun as we age. We take on responsibilities that create worry. We become fearful of getting hurt and so are unwilling to take risks or try new things. We become set in our ways and unwilling to explore.

One of the great blessings of grandchildren is that they remind me of what it means to have fun. They are often loud, messy and chaotic. But they aren't being bad.

They are just having fun. One movie night the kids set up the folding table that allows all 13 of us to eat together. Halfway through the meal one of the legs on the folding table collapsed and everyone's plates slid onto the floor. They thought that was the funniest thing that had ever happened!

You have to learn how to accept chaos to have a fun community. Walls will have fingerprints. Stuff will get broken. Food will end up on the floor...and elsewhere as well. But as long as everyone is laughing and having fun it is all worth it.

Broken things can get fixed. Walls can be washed. Laughter and community are worth the trouble.

I am committed that being at my house will be fun regardless of the cost. My community is important to me.

Civility Part 10: Civility and COVID-19

Originally posted 3/24/2020

"In the midst of winter, I found there was, within me, an invincible summer."

— Albert Camus

Covid-19 is a big deal. Life, as we have come to know it, has come to a halt. You and I are staying home, avoiding contact with family, friends and coworkers. The virus continues to spread and we all hope that doctors and scientists will quickly develop an effective treatment or vaccine. Until that happens, we all need to wash our hands, stay calm and love the ones you're with.

Crises like this somehow bring out the best in human nature. Our first reaction is shock. How can this be happening? How will I work from home? Or, if I am laid off from a job that suddenly disappeared, how will I pay my rent or feed my children?

But we can only be shocked for so long. Once the drama wears off, a different (and better) sentiment kicks in. Who needs my help? Who are the elderly and vulnerable people in my community that need groceries delivered to their door? Where are the local restaurants from which I can order delivery or pick up to try to keep their doors open?

People come together in tough times. Families who hardly spend any time together are taking walks, playing board games or cleaning up the yard. Friends are checking in with each other over the phone and video chat. Companies are shifting from manufacturing their products to make hand sanitizer, face masks and respirators.

America is a great country. When the chips are down our people know how to stand up and stand strong. We are proud of who we are, and we pull together to make certain we come through this together.

But it isn't just about Americans. Trials and difficulties bring out the best in human beings. We are reminded that we are in the game of life together. We put aside competing in order to collaborate in each other's survival.

Today, let's celebrate our human spirit and do whatever you can to help your neighbor endure. And when this is over, please do not forget the lesson we are all learning about the value of togetherness and community.

Questions for Reflection (Essays 6 -10)

Civility Part 6: Allies or Enemies?

Reflection Question: How do people experience me in everyday interactions—am I building allies, or unknowingly pushing people away?

Civility Part 7: Being a Plow Horse or Reservoir

Reflection Question: Am I caring for others in a way that depletes me—or am I building rhythms that allow me to give from abundance?

Civility Part 8: Loner or Lover?

Reflection Question: What is one small thing I can do this week to strengthen the sense of connection in my family or community?

Questions for Reflection (Essays 6 -10)

Civility Part 9: Community Building

Reflection Question: What is the vision I want to create for my community—and what small, intentional step can I take this week to move toward it?

Civility Part 9: Community Building

Reflection Question: What kind of atmosphere do I want to create in my home or group—and how can I be more intentional in shaping it?

Civility Part 10: Civility and COVID-19

Reflection Question: During difficult times, what does it look like for me to lead with empathy, calm, and care?

Civility Part 11: Civility and Individuality

Originally posted 6/2/2020

“Freedom is the open window through which pours the sunlight of the human spirit and human dignity.”

— Herbert Hoover

One thing that makes America so special is the balance between the rights of the individual and the value of the community. Each of us is guaranteed certain liberties that allow us to pursue our goals and enrich our lives. At the same time, we must keep in view the value of the collective whole. If I pursue my interests in ways that undermine the group, I weaken the very system upon which my rights are built. If I value the group to the point that individuality is suppressed, I undermine the freedom upon which prosperity is built.

I suspect that this balance is not an easy one to strike. Our forefathers seemed to have found it quite well. That does not seem to be the case with our present generation. We are witnessing a nation divided on numerous fronts. We are separating by race, wealth, and political persuasion. Each side is taking a radical stance that focuses on their side and may be overlooking the value of coming together around common goals.

We can pull this great country apart. We have the ability to rip it to shreds by insisting on our point of view without sufficiently valuing the views of those whose lives are very different from ours. Each of us has a voice. Each voice should be heard. It is best heard in a climate of dignity and mutual respect. It is best heard when everyone recognizes the values we share. We are a great nation because every soul in this country is important. We must move forward, but we can only move forward together.

Let's celebrate those who are different from ourselves. Let's listen to their point of view.

Let's work together to build a system that works better for everyone.

Civility Part 12: Civility and Grace

Originally posted 3/24/2020

“Grace means that all of your mistakes now serve a purpose instead of serving shame.”

— Brené Brown

Grace is not a concept used much today.

One dictionary definition is “courteous goodwill.” The Bible uses the term “grace” in a much more powerful manner. It describes God’s “unmerited favor” toward the world. We need more unmerited favor toward each other.

Unmerited favor means showing respect to people who disagree with our point of view and, perhaps, even seeking to soften or change our thoughts in response to what we might have to learn.

Unmerited favor means overlooking insult and injustice we have suffered because we are less concerned with how we are treated than with how we treat others.

Unmerited favor means showing kindness and generosity toward those who have less than us and going out of our way to show courtesy to everyone despite the color of their skin or their station in life.

Unmerited favor means making the world a better place to the best of our ability by supporting dignity, justice and equality for all in how we think and act every day.

We all have the power to choose to be people of grace.

Let us make that choice.





“Do your little bit of good
where you are; it’s those
little bits of good put
together that overwhelm
the world.”

Bishop Desmond Tutu

Civility Part 13: Civility and Presence

"Wherever you are, be all there."

— *Jim Elliot*

The most generous gift you can offer another person is your attention. We all know what it feels like to be in a conversation where someone is distracted, glancing at their phone, or mentally somewhere else. You feel invisible, unimportant. On the other hand, being with someone who is fully present—who looks you in the eye, listens without interrupting, and isn't rushing to respond—feels rare, meaningful, and deeply respectful.

Presence is an act of civility. It says, "You matter. Right now, you have my full attention." In this noisy world, that's a powerful message.

But presence doesn't come easily. It requires intention. Our minds are cluttered with worries, tasks, and distractions. To be fully present, you must quiet your mind. Set aside your to-do list. Let go of your need to fix, solve, or judge.

Just show up.

Presence is not about perfection. You don't need to say all the right things. Often, you don't need to say anything at all.

Just listen. Just be there.

Whether it's with your spouse, your child, your coworker or a stranger at the grocery store—practice presence. It may be the kindest thing you do all day.

Practice this week. In one conversation each day, put your phone away. Make eye contact. Listen without interrupting.

Let the person know, by your stillness, that they matter.

Civility Part 14: Civility and Forgiveness

“To forgive is to set a prisoner free and discover that the prisoner was you.”

— Lewis B. Smedes

Forgiveness is one of the greatest acts of civility.

It is the choice to release resentment, to soften your grip on an offense, and to see the humanity in the one who hurt you. Forgiveness doesn't mean forgetting. It doesn't mean you were wrong to be hurt. But it does mean that you refuse to live in the grip of bitterness.

We often wait for the apology. We wait for justice. We wait for things to be made right. But waiting can keep us stuck. Civility invites us to move forward not always because the other person deserves it, but because we deserve peace.

Forgiveness is radical because it shifts the power. It puts you back in charge of your life. You are no longer tethered to the one who wronged you. You are no longer defined by the pain. You get to choose freedom.

Start small. Is there someone you need to forgive?

Maybe it's a spouse, a coworker, a parent, a friend. Maybe it's yourself. Write a letter, even if you never send it.

Speak the words out loud, even if no one hears.

Let the power of forgiveness begin its healing work.



Civility Part 15: Civility and Staying Open

“Keep your heart open, even if it hurts.”

— Unknown

Civility is often tested in moments when we feel threatened, offended, or deeply misunderstood. These are the moments when everything in us wants to shut down—when we want to pull back, dig in, lash out, or walk away.

But there is power in staying open.

To stay open is not to agree. It's not to surrender your values or silence your truth. Staying open is simply the choice to remain present, curious, and grounded even when it's uncomfortable.

Especially when it's uncomfortable.

When someone speaks to you in anger, can you stay open to what pain might lie beneath?
When a loved one disappoints you, can you remain open to reconciliation?

When the world feels loud, divided, and cynical—can you still choose to respond with grace?
Civility is the practice of softening your response without losing your strength.

We are shaped not just by the big decisions we make, but by the small ones we repeat daily. Choosing to stay open is one of those decisions. And like any habit, it strengthens over time. It may not always be safe to stay open in every relationship. Boundaries matter. But in most everyday situations—with friends, coworkers, neighbors, even strangers—a posture of openness can shift the entire tone of an interaction.

Try it this week. When you feel your chest tighten and your jaw clench, take a breath.

Notice your instinct to react, and choose instead to remain open just a little longer.

Ask a question. Offer the benefit of the doubt. Let the silence stretch a few more seconds. You might be surprised what shifts when you do.

“No act of kindness,
no matter how small,
is ever wasted.”

Aesop

Civility Part 16: Civility and Everyday Leadership

“Leadership is not about being in charge. It is about taking care of those in your charge.”

— Simon Sinek

As the familiar saying goes, you don’t need a title to lead. You certainly don’t need a stage or a platform. Leadership begins with how you treat people—especially those with no power to repay you.

Civility is everyday leadership. It’s choosing kindness when no one is watching. It’s responding with grace under pressure. It’s being consistent in your character, even when others are not.

I once worked with a man who never raised his voice, never boasted about his achievements, and never demanded the spotlight. But he made everyone around him feel safe, valued, and inspired.

He led by example. He built trust.

People wanted to follow him not because they had to, but because they **wanted** to.

You can do that too. Say thank you. Offer help. Keep your word. Speak truth without harshness. Encourage someone who feels small.

These small acts of civility are the building blocks of true leadership. And the world is hungry for more of it.

Practice leading this week. Don’t wait for a promotion or permission. Choose to lead by the way you live.

Questions for Reflection (Essays 11 -16)

Civility Part 11: Civility and Individuality

Reflection Question: How can I honor both my individuality and the needs of the larger community in the way I show up each day?

Civility Part 12: Civility and Grace

Reflection Question: Where in my life can I offer unmerited kindness—especially to someone who may not expect it?

Civility Part 13: Civility and Presence

Reflection Question: Who in my life most needs my full attention right now—and how can I be truly present with them?

Questions for Reflection (Essays 11 -16)

Civility Part 14: Civility and Forgiveness

Is there someone I need to forgive—or ask forgiveness from—so I can be more free and whole?

Civility Part 15: Civility and Staying Open

Reflection Question: What situation in my life right now is inviting me to stay open—when my instinct is to shut down or walk away?

Civility Part 16: Civility and Everyday Leadership

Reflection Question: What is one small act of integrity or encouragement I can offer today that reflects the kind of leader I want to be?



Closing Thoughts

A Path Toward a Life with More Civility

Civility isn't a simple switch that you can flip on or off. It's a state of being; an awareness that you choose in every moment. And like any discipline worth practicing, it takes effort, patience, and a willingness to begin again.

These brief essays have explored some of what it means to be present, to listen well, to forgive, to set boundaries, and how to show up for your community.

None of these are flashy. You won't find awards for doing them. But they are the quiet acts that can powerfully shape our lives and the lives of those around us.

In a world where division is easy and reaction (and overreaction) is rewarded, choosing civility is a countercultural move. It means slowing down when others speed up. It means pausing before you react or post on social media. It means holding yourself to a standard of grace even when others fall short.

You may be the only voice of calm in a heated conversation. You may be the only one willing to forgive, or to admit fault. You may be the first to say, "I'm sorry." That doesn't make you weak. It makes you a leader.

Always remember that there's a ripple effect to civility. It begins with you, but it never ends there. One act of kindness inevitably leads to another. One courageous boundary empowers someone else. One moment of grace creates a path for healing that can change the course of someone's life. As Bishop Tutu observed, these are "the little bits of good put together" that can "overwhelm the world" in a wondrous butterfly effect of love and compassion.

My hope is that you'll continue this work long after the last page. That you'll start small and stay consistent. That you'll teach civility not just with your words, but with your presence.

The world doesn't need more noise.

It needs more people who lead with love.

Let it begin with you.

Jack

Civility Log

Take a few moments each day to reflect on how you practiced civility—in your words, actions, and presence. Each small entry is a step toward a stronger, kinder life.

MONDAY	TUESDAY	WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY

Notes:

Civility Journal

*Use this space to capture moments of kindness, presence, and growth throughout the month.
Small acts, noted over time, reveal the deeper story you are creating.*

MONDAY



TUESDAY



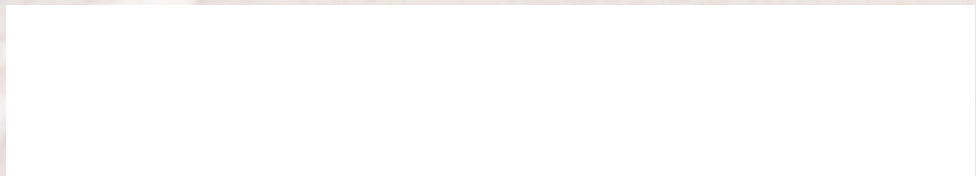
WEDNESDAY



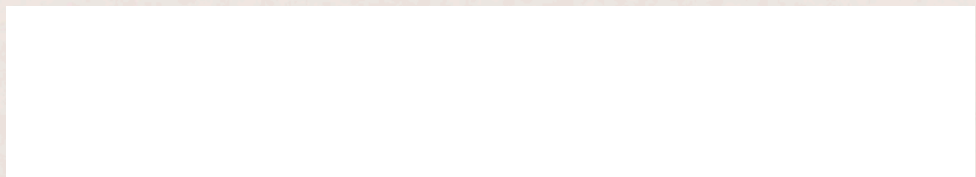
THURSDAY



FRIDAY



SATURDAY



SUNDAY



What if small simple acts could change everything?

In a noisy, divided world, civility isn't a luxury—it's a necessity.

It's the quiet strength that builds trust.

It's the steady presence that opens hearts.

It's the everyday leadership that lifts communities.

In *The Civility Essays*, Dr. Jack Skeen invites you to rediscover the transformative power of kindness, listening, forgiveness, presence, and grace. Originally shared as personal reflections, these short essays struck a deep chord—offering hope, direction, and encouragement. Now, for the first time, these essays are gathered into one volume—expanded and enriched with timeless quotes and questions for reflection.



You'll discover:

- How to shift from self-focus to others-focus
- How to listen with true curiosity
- How to forgive and free yourself from bitterness
- How to stay open, even when it's hard
- How to lead quietly, powerfully, every day

Civility isn't weakness. It's strength under control.

Civility isn't about being liked.

It's about living true to who you are.

*Dr. Jack Skeen is a trusted executive coach, author, and speaker known for his rare ability to blend wisdom, candor, and compassion. With decades of experience helping leaders and organizations grow with integrity, Jack's work centers on what it means to live—and lead—with authenticity. His writing invites readers to slow down, listen deeply, and live with greater presence and purpose. He is the author of *The Circle Blueprint* and *The Civility Essays*, and the founder of Skeen Leadership Group.*